The Life You *Choose*

THE MADE REAL BLUEPRINT / STEP 3

Go and change where I am

Do I change my life where I am, or do I move?

A written request for four days, with my notice period, and the first Friday off.

Sam · In 8 weeks

MY FIVE LIGHTS / AS I RECORDED THEM

Money	Papers	People	Place	Plan B
Amber	Green	Green	Green	Green
One full month lived on €2,360, with the rent and the bills paid out of it	Nothing to arrange. Same country, same contract, same address	My sister knows, and my manager has agreed to a meeting	I stay in the flat I know, at the rent I know	Four days is reversible, and the reserve is untouched

The colours are my own answers on the day. Nothing here says that anything is ready.

THE CONDITIONS STILL OPEN

- **Money** — After the first month

  One full month lived on €2,360, with the rent and the bills paid out of it

My first step: Ask my manager for a meeting about a four-day week. In the first week.

02 / MONEY

What the numbers can carry

Monthly costs €2,198

Income I can count on €2,360

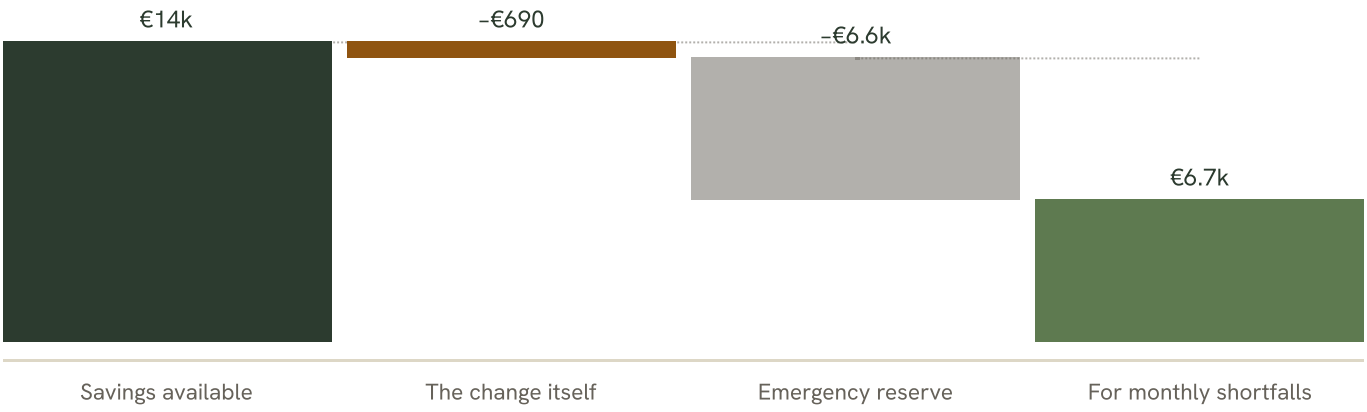
€162

left over each month

On the income I can count on today.

Step 1 guessed €2,210 a month. Step 2 found €2,198, 1% less.

HOW €14,000 BECOMES €6,710 TO LIVE ON



6

months I want

If everything costs 30% more: Costs €2,873 and I am €513 short each month. The reserve covers about 13 months. I would go back to five days for a season rather than spend it.

My runway divides the money left to live on (€6,710), not my savings: the reserve and the return fund are kept out of it on purpose. Nothing here is advice; these are my own figures.

RISK AND A WAY BACK

What I will watch

What I want is already here. The four-week test worked on six evenings out of eight. Moving would cost me the people I stay for.

01 **I get the time and fill it with work again**

Warning sign: Two Fridays in a row where I do not leave the house

A standing Friday with my sister, so somebody is expecting me

02 **My manager says no**

Warning sign: The meeting keeps being moved

Keep the two evenings, ask again after six months, one unpaid day a month meanwhile

03 **Four-fifths pay turns out to be tight**

Warning sign: The first month ends with nothing left over

Live on the lower figure for a month before I sign anything

My own judgement of what could go wrong. The warning signs are things I will look for, not predictions.

MY WAY BACK

Keep a home. Protect a return fund.

Not needed. The equivalent is the reserve, and the fact that four days is reversible.

My five-day contract until the four-day one is signed. My reserve of €6,600, untouched.

THE ALTERNATIVE STILL ON THE TABLE

Nothing changes, nothing is risked, and the money stays where it is.

FROM DECISION TO ACTION

The order I will do this in

One full month on four-fifths pay, with the rent and the bills paid out of it.

1

FIRST WEEK

Ask my manager for a meeting

What must be true first: A month of figures I believe

2

FIRST MONTH

Live on four-fifths pay on paper

What must be true first: Last three months of spending in front of me

3

SECOND MONTH

Put the request in writing

What must be true first: A yes in principle

4

THIRD MONTH

Take a corner of a neighbour's allotment

What must be true first: Tools and boots

5

FOURTH MONTH

First Friday outdoors

What must be true first: The change in place

A COMMITMENT I KEEP FOR LATER

I rent, and I keep renting. A four-day week is not the month to take on a mortgage.

LOOK AGAIN / IN 8 WEEKS

A flat no from work with no room in it, or a month on the lower pay that does not add up.

Decided with: Me, with my sister. We agree.

IF I AM STAYING

My change plan

Four days a week in the same job, with Friday outdoors, and two evenings a week that end at six.

In place by In the fourth month.

1

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MONEY AND BUFFER

€2,360 a month from the fourth month, confirmed, against €2,210 of costs. The buffer stays at €6,600, three months of everything, untouched.

HOURS I DECIDE, BEFORE AND AFTER

About 16 hours a week now. About 26 after the change.

IF I AM STAYING

Who it rests on, and the way back

WHO I TELL

My sister first, then my manager, then the team. From my sister I need a standing Friday, so somebody is expecting me.

MY FIRST 90 DAYS

Week one, the meeting. After 30 days, two evenings a week that really end at six. After 90 days, the request agreed and in writing.

MY PLAN B

If four days is refused, I keep the two evenings and ask again after six months, with one unpaid day a month meanwhile. If the lower pay does not add up, I go back to five days for a season rather than spend the reserve.

I look at this again: the third month after the change, and again after a year. Staying is a decision like any other, and this is the plan that goes with it.